

TRUE COLOURS
(Clockwise from left) *Cul de sac in Takshilla*, Ranbir Kaleka; *Birth 2*, Nilima Sheikh; *Germination*, S.H. Raza; *Face*, Rabindranath Tagore

ART/ BOOKS

A GOOD BIG ELEPHANT

Modern and contemporary Indian art now has that essential critical compendium it needed

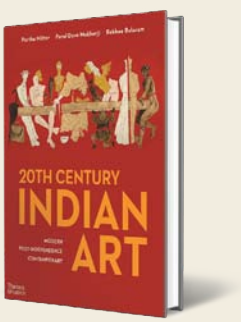
the exception of cinema. The book is divided into four sections that—quite logically—overlap somewhat: the first part brings us from the last couple of decades before the turn of the century till 1947; the second part lays out the period roughly from the 1930s to 1990-91; the third part maps and explores the situation from the rupture of globalisation almost to the current moment; and the fourth part provides a brief but very necessary foray into the histories of modernism in Pakistan, Nepal, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Myanmar.

Besides the editors' essays which concisely introduce each section, there is writing from about 40 different critics who have written about the subject. Included also are interviews with artists and critics. Throughout the volume, we find boxes with memoirs and anecdotes such as Gulammohammed Sheikh's moving tribute to his friend Bhupen Khakhar and Jyotindra Jain's hilarious and troubling story about Rauschenberg/ Roshandan's encounter with a traditional block printer in Kutch. These and the short biographical notes provide important narrative release valves from the continual track of the critical essays.

As one would want with a book such as this, you can spend hours moving about within its covers without reading a single word. You can begin a material trek from the oily impastos and chiaroscuros of the late 19th century, move through the lithographs and watercolours of the early 20th, to the cloth and plaster of Dashrath Patel's *Dargah* and the bronze 'dhokra' of Meera Mukherjee's *Ashoka at Kalinga*, or you could do a connecting archaeology of a certain kind of figure, say from Abanindranath's *Bharat Mata* to Amrita Sher-Gil's *Three Girls* to Nilima Sheikh's *When Champa Grew Up* to Nalini Malani's *Old Arguments on Indigenism*. The book, with its 600-odd illustrations, is thus full of possible rewarding games of visual snakes and ladders.

A huge project such as this is bound to contain some errors and professional boo-boo spotters will also likely have a good time combing through its pages. Regrettably, one blooper is to be found in the very first paragraph of the Introduction: 'Geopolitics intervened in the middle of the century, bifurcating the old subcontinent into two new states in 1947: the new Indian Republic and the Islamic Republic of West and East Pakistan (later to be *renamed* Bangladesh)' (italics mine). Sensitive Bangladeshis may take umbrage, but eventually one suspects they might forgive the editors. All in all, even if you want to argue with different corners of it, this is a good big elephant of a book to have in the room. ■

–Ruchir Joshi



20TH CENTURY INDIAN ART: Modern, Post-Independence, Contemporary
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